

the direction of my career I encountered my epiphany about the millionaire-next-door segment one morning at a task force meeting with my client and a colleague and friend, Jon Robbin. Jon is a Harvard-trained mathematician who profiled the wealth characteristics of the residents within each of more than 200,000 neighborhoods across America. He said, in passing, “About one-half of the millionaires in America don’t live in upscale neighborhoods.” That’s when the light went on inside my head! The really compelling story was not the millionaire population in general. Rather it was the low-profile millionaires, the ones who lived in modest homes situated in middle-class, even working-class neighborhoods. From that moment on, I intensely began studying and writing about the millionaire-next-door types. The research that I conducted thirty years ago in 1980 was the first comprehensive national study about the size, geographic distribution, and financial lifestyles of millionaires. The key findings were highly congruent with the numerous studies that I have conducted since that time.

I authored “The National Affluent Study 1981-1982” for a consortium of the top fifty financial institutions in America. In addition to designing this study, I traveled the country conducting focus group interviews with millionaires. Later, many of these financial institutions, including seven of the top ten trust companies in America, asked me to conduct focus group interviews and surveys of the affluent on their behalf. As a result, I had the opportunity to meet with more than 500 millionaires face to face. My interpretation of these interviews as well as many others that I conducted is given throughout *The Millionaire Next Door*. Interestingly, the millionaires I interviewed in Oklahoma and Texas, for example, had the same set of traditional American values as those whom I interviewed in New York City and Chicago. The large majority was keenly interested in being financially independent. That’s why they lived below their means.

Prior to writing *The Millionaire Next Door*, I spent nearly an entire year reviewing my survey data and the transcripts of the interviews conducted between 1982 and 1996. This extensive research and analysis, I believe, is what makes *The Millionaire Next Door* a perennial best seller. For the price of a book, the reader is essentially buying the equivalent of more than \$1 million worth of invaluable research and interpretation.

Why do I continue to write about rich people? It is not for the benefit of rich people! What I write is designed to enlighten those who are